10,000 BLACK INTERNS · CLASS OF 2027 · REFLECTIVE WORKBOOK

Finding your why

A guided way to turn your values, upbringing and experiences into a motivation for Investment Management, Sales and Public Relations that nobody else could have written, and that you can talk about confidently in any interview.

1 · Dig

Exercises to surface your real values, memories and moments

2 · Connect

Link each value to how the industry actually works

3 · Write

Original angles, a cliché detector and assembly templates

This is a workbook. Print it or write your answers in a notes app. Nothing here assumes anything about your background: every prompt is optional, and you choose what to share. Highlighted [brackets] mark where only your real details can go. Section references like "Guide B10" point to the Industry Guide PDF. Prepared October 2026.

NAVIGATION

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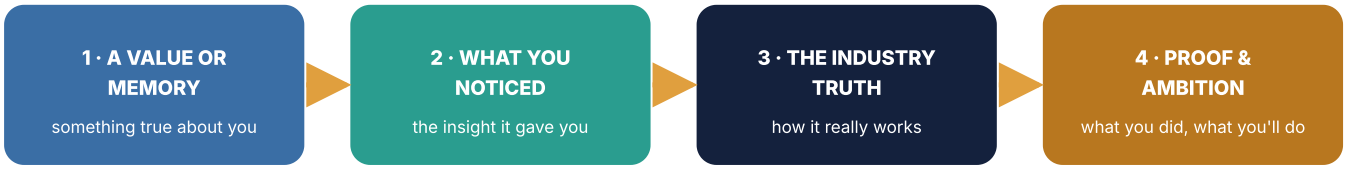
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How long this takes: give Part 1 about an hour, in one sitting, and write fast without editing. Part 2 takes 15 minutes. Then pick angles from Part 3 and assemble in Part 5. The deadline is 1 November, so do Part 1 today.

What a great "why" actually is

Most applicants say *what* they want ("I want to work in investment management"). Good applicants say *why* in general terms ("because I'm interested in markets"). The best applicants show a **personal reason that connects to how the industry actually works**, and prove it with something they did.



The "motivation chain". A value with no industry truth is just a nice story. Industry knowledge with no value is a textbook. You need both, joined.

What "outside the box" means here

It does **not** mean gimmicky, dramatic or exaggerated. It means **an angle that's true but unexpected**, a link the reader hasn't seen 30 times that day. The surprise usually comes from connecting something ordinary from your life to something specific about the industry:

Expected

"I've always been interested in finance and the stock market."

Unexpected but true

"The most important financial decision in my family was never about the stock market. It was about whether to keep money in a savings account that was quietly losing to inflation."

Why it works

Personal, specific and humble, and it leads straight into the real purpose of investment management (Guide A2, B1).

Three rules for writing about values and upbringing

1 · Lesson, not life story. One moment, then what it taught you. Spend at most 30–40 words of 250 on the memory, and the rest on what it means now.

2 · Show, don't label. "I'm resilient" is a claim. "I sent 40 emails before I got my first reply" is proof.

3 · Only what you're happy to expand on. Interviewers often say "tell me more about that". Share only what you'd be comfortable talking about for two minutes. You never have to disclose anything personal you'd rather keep private.

1

Dig

Four short exercise sets. Write quickly and honestly, and don't edit yet. You're mining for raw material. Most of it won't be used, but one or two lines will become the spine of your answers.

1. Your money story
2. Your values
3. Moments, people and frustrations
4. Mining your asset management experience

1A · Your money story

Everyone grows up with messages about money: spoken or unspoken, positive or difficult. These are some of the most powerful raw materials for an investment management answer, because the industry exists to answer one question: **how do ordinary people's savings grow and stay safe over a lifetime?**

1. What's your earliest memory involving money, whether saving, spending, worrying or celebrating?

2. Growing up, what did the adults around you say or believe about money? (e.g. "save for a rainy day", "don't trust banks", "property is the only safe investment", "never borrow")

3. Who in your family or community was "good with money"? What did they do differently?

4. Did you ever see a money decision go well, or badly, for someone close to you? What made the difference?

5. When did you first realise that money could *grow* (interest, investing, a business), and not just be earned and spent?

6. Have you noticed prices rising, at home, at the shops or on rent, and what it meant for people's choices?

7. Did anyone in your life save into a pension, an ISA or a property, or send money to family elsewhere? What did that teach you about responsibility and the long term?

ZERO-KNOWLEDGE EXPLAINER

What to look for in your answers: phrases about **patience**, **security**, **responsibility for others**, **trust or distrust of institutions**, **the long term**, **small habits adding up**, or **knowledge gaps** (people not knowing their options). Each of these maps directly onto a real truth about investment management (see Part 2).

1B · Your values

Step 1: tick every value that genuinely describes how you were raised or how you try to live. Aim for 10–15.

☐ Responsibility ☐ Family ☐ Faith ☐ Hard work ☐ Patience ☐ Discipline ☐ Honesty ☐ Integrity ☐ Loyalty ☐ Respect ☐ Service to others ☐ Community ☐ Independence ☐ Ambition ☐ Curiosity ☐ Learning ☐ Excellence ☐ Resilience ☐ Courage ☐ Fairness ☐ Opportunity ☐ Gratitude ☐ Humility ☐ Generosity ☐ Reliability ☐ Keeping promises ☐ Representation ☐ Creativity ☐ Competitiveness ☐ Calm under pressure ☐ Making people feel heard ☐ Long-term thinking ☐ Building something ☐ Being trusted ☐ Clarity ☐ Pride in where I'm from ☐ Helping others understand ☐ Leaving things better

Step 2: cut it down to your **top 5**. **Step 3:** for each one, write **where it came from** (a person, a saying, a moment) and **one time you acted on it**.

Top value	Where it came from (who / what / when)	One time I acted on it

Step 4: Is there a phrase you heard over and over growing up, a saying from a parent, grandparent, coach, teacher or faith leader, that still guides you?

Step 5: What do people who know you well rely on you for?

EXPERT INSIGHT

Values become credible when they have an origin and an action. "I value responsibility" is empty. "My mum [or whoever it really was] used to say [the actual phrase], and I saw what it meant when [moment]" is a story. One origin plus one action is enough.

1C · Moments, people and frustrations

Moments of pride

A time you persuaded someone to change their mind. How did you do it?

A time you kept going after being rejected or told no

A time you explained something complicated so someone finally understood it

A time you stayed calm when others didn't

Something you sold, organised, raised money for or built

People and frustrations

Who do you trust most, and why? What do they do that earns trust?

Who's the best communicator you know? What do they do differently?

What annoys you about how things are explained, sold or reported, to you or your family?

When did you see someone or something misrepresented (in the news, online, at school), and how did it feel?

What do you lose track of time doing?

ZERO-KNOWLEDGE EXPLAINER

Why frustrations are gold: a strong "why" often starts with something you noticed was *wrong* or *missing*. For example: people not understanding their pension, a salesperson who didn't listen, a story told unfairly. Industries exist to fix problems, and a frustration shows you've noticed one. Keep the tone constructive: "I saw a gap, and I want to be part of closing it."

1D · Mining your asset management experience

Your previous asset management role is your biggest asset. But "I did an internship" is a fact, not a motivation. The motivation lies in **what you noticed and felt** while you were there. Answer these as specifically as you can.

What was the moment you thought "this is interesting"? Where were you and what was happening?

What did you produce or contribute that someone actually used?

What surprised you about how the firm actually worked, compared with what you expected?

Did you see anything client-facing: a pitch, a report, an RFP, a client meeting? What struck you?

Who impressed you most, and what exactly did they do? (e.g. how they handled a client, explained a fund, ran a meeting)

Did you see how the firm communicated externally (press, commentary, social media)? What did you notice?

What was the hardest task you did, and how did you approach it?

What do you want to learn next that you didn't get to?

If your answer mentions...	...it's raw material for
Client meetings, reports, explaining performance	**IM** (client-facing angle) and **Sales** (consultative selling)
Pitches, RFPs, winning or losing business	**Sales** (the B2B cycle, Guide C6) and **IM** distribution
Market commentary, press, how the firm "sounded"	**PR** (financial communications, Guide D6)
Analysis, data, Excel, research	**IM** (investment literacy) and **Sales** (pipeline analysis)
A person whose behaviour you admired	Any of the three, as your "role model moment"

Part 2 · Values → industry map

Find your top 5 values in the left column. Each one already has a genuine counterpart in each industry, and that counterpart is your bridge from "who I am" to "why this industry".

Value	Investment Management	Sales	Public Relations
Responsibility for others	Fiduciary duty: managing other people's retirements (Guide A4)	Selling only what genuinely helps; accountability for a number	Protecting a client's reputation as if it were your own
Patience / long-term thinking	Compounding; long-horizon pension investing (Guide A3)	Long B2B sales cycles; relationships that pay off over years	Reputation built over years; long-term media relationships
Honesty / integrity	Consumer Duty, fair value, clear reporting (Guide B12)	Ethical selling; the lessons of mis-selling (Guide C4)	Never lie in a crisis; credibility with journalists (Guide D5)
Family / community	DC pensions and savings decide how families live in retirement	Understanding people's real needs; earning referrals	How communities are represented and spoken to
Hard work / resilience	Performance pressure; markets don't care about excuses	Rejection is daily; pipeline is earned call by call	Deadlines, breaking news, rejected pitches
Curiosity / learning	Research, markets, constantly changing economics	Discovery: asking better questions than competitors	News sense; understanding audiences and trends
Helping others understand	Product specialists and client managers translate complexity	Explaining value so the buyer sees it themselves	Turning complex messages into clear stories
Being trusted / reliability	Client retention: trust is the product (Guide B5)	Account management, renewals and NRR	Becoming a source journalists rely on
Fairness / opportunity	Widening access to investing; diverse decision-making	Meritocracy: results speak for themselves	Fair representation; countering misinformation
Calm under pressure	Talking clients through market falls	Negotiation; handling objections	Crisis communications in the "golden hour"
Ambition / building	Growing assets and client relationships	Quotas, OTE, a fast career ladder	Winning clients, campaigns and awards
Faith / gratitude / humility	Stewardship: looking after what has been entrusted to you	Service mindset: success through serving others	Owning mistakes honestly (e.g. KFC "FCK", Guide D5)

Your output from Part 2: for each industry, circle the **one** value with the strongest true story behind it. That becomes the opening of that answer. Ideally, use a different value for each industry so the three answers don't read the same.

Industry	My chosen value	The true story / moment behind it
Investment Management		
Sales		
Public Relations		

3

Outside-the-box angles

Seven or eight original motivation angles for each industry. Each one shows the industry truth behind it, the kind of personal story it needs, a sample line with your details left blank, and when *not* to use it. Pick the one or two that are genuinely true for you, and ignore the rest.

1. Investment Management angles
2. Sales angles
3. Public Relations angles

3A · Investment Management angles

1 · Inflation at the kitchen table

TRUTH Cash loses real value when interest is below inflation. That's the whole reason investing exists (Guide A2).

NEEDS A memory of prices rising, saving in cash, or a family money conversation

LINE *"Watching* **[who]** *save carefully into an account that paid less than inflation taught me that being responsible with money isn't enough on its own. It has to be invested well."*

AVOID IF You'd rather not discuss family finances in an interview

2 · Compounding as a life philosophy

TRUTH Small, consistent gains snowball, and so do small fee differences (Guide A3)

NEEDS A habit you built over time: training, study, saving, practising a skill

LINE *"* **[Your habit]** *taught me that small, consistent effort compounds, which is exactly what drew me to an industry where decades of patient decisions shape whether millions retire comfortably."*

AVOID IF The habit is trivial or you can't describe the payoff

3 · The invisible custodian

TRUTH Almost everyone is an asset manager's client through their pension, yet few know it (Guide B1)

NEEDS Noticing that you or people around you didn't know where your pension or savings were invested

LINE *"Until my internship, I didn't know that my own workplace pension* **[or a family member's]** *was managed by firms like the one I was sitting in. Most people never find out."*

AVOID IF You can't link it to wanting to make the client side clearer

4 · The translator

TRUTH Client-facing roles translate complex investment processes into confidence (Guide B5)

NEEDS A time you translated between worlds: generations, languages, cultures, school and home, experts and beginners

LINE *"I grew up* **[translating letters for / explaining forms to / tutoring]** **[who]** *, so I've always noticed the gap between how experts speak and what people need to hear."*

AVOID IF It isn't genuinely part of your life

5 · Ownership and a voice

TRUTH Investors own companies and vote on how they're run. This is stewardship (Guide B7).

NEEDS An interest in how companies behave, or the realisation that "a share is ownership"

LINE *"What changed my view of the industry was realising that a fund doesn't just hold shares. It holds a voice in how hundreds of companies are run."*

AVOID IF You can't talk about stewardship or voting in an interview

6 · Keeping trust is harder than earning it

TRUTH Retention protects recurring fee revenue; one bad meeting can lose a mandate (Guide B5, B10)

NEEDS A part-time job, team or role where you kept a customer's or a group's trust over time

LINE *"At* **[job]** *I learned that regulars came back because of how we treated them, not one great day. It's the same reason a client stays with an asset manager through a bad year."*

AVOID IF The example has no element of long-term relationships

7 · Widening the circle of investors

TRUTH DC pensions and ISAs are pushing millions more people towards investing, and many lack confidence (Guide B13)

NEEDS A genuine observation: friends who don't invest, family who distrust it, your own learning curve

LINE *"Many people I grew up around* **[kept savings in cash / didn't trust investing]** *. Not because they were careless, but because nobody explained it to them in a way that made sense."*

AVOID IF It becomes a speech. Keep it to one observation, then the industry.

8 · Patience in a world of instant results

TRUTH Institutions invest over decades, while markets and social media reward short-termism (Guide B4)

NEEDS A value of patience, faith, delayed gratification, or a long project you saw through

LINE *"In a world built around instant results, I'm drawn to an industry whose best decisions are judged over ten or twenty years."*

AVOID IF You can't back it with something you did patiently

3B · Sales angles

1 · The first thing I ever sold

TRUTH Every business runs on someone finding a customer and earning their yes (Guide C1)

NEEDS Selling something at school, reselling clothes or trainers, a family business, a market stall, a fundraiser

LINE *"The first thing I ever sold was* **[what]** *. I learned more from the* **[number]** *people who said no than from the ones who said yes."*

AVOID IF It can't lead into a real lesson about customers

2 · Listening is the product

TRUTH Discovery and consultative selling win; buyers arrive informed (Guide C3, C4)

NEEDS Someone who earned your trust by listening, or a time listening changed an outcome

LINE *"The best salesperson I ever met barely talked about the product.* **[What they did instead]** *."*

AVOID IF You can't describe the person or moment specifically

3 · Rejection as training

TRUTH The funnel means most attempts fail, so resilience is structural (Guide C5)

NEEDS Sport, auditions, applications or cold outreach where "no" was normal

LINE *"* **[Sport / activity]** *taught me that losing is information. Sales is the only job I know where that mindset is literally built into the numbers."*

AVOID IF You'd be making the resilience sound bigger than it was

4 · Sales is service

TRUTH Ethical, value-based selling builds repeat business; pushy selling destroys it (Guide C4)

NEEDS A value of service or faith, or a bad experience of being "sold to"

LINE *"I was raised to believe* **[the value / saying]** *, which is why the sales I admire start with what the customer needs, not what the seller wants to hit."*

AVOID IF You can't show you also respect targets and results

5 · The numbers behind persuasion

TRUTH Modern sales is data-driven: pipeline, conversion, churn (Guide C5)

NEEDS Liking data, a time you tracked results and improved them

LINE *"What surprised me about sales is how measurable persuasion is. Every stage of a pipeline tells you where trust was won or lost."*

AVOID IF You'd struggle to explain a sales funnel in an interview

6 · Relationships compound

TRUTH Account management and retention drive most revenue in recurring businesses (Guide C2)

NEEDS Long relationships you've kept: regular customers, a mentoring role, a community

LINE *"In* **[community / job]** *, the people who did best were the ones everyone trusted after years, not the loudest in the room. That's the kind of salesperson I want to become."*

AVOID IF It reads as avoiding the "closing" side; mention both

7 · I watched a £multi-million sale up close

TRUTH Asset management distribution is consultative B2B sales (Guide C6)

NEEDS Something client-facing you saw in your AM role

LINE *"Before my internship, I didn't think of fund management as sales. Then I watched* **[pitch / RFP / client meeting]** *and saw a months-long sale with five decision-makers."*

AVOID IF The reader might be a consumer brand. Keep it in sales language.

8 · Translator (sales version)

TRUTH Value selling means expressing a product in the buyer's terms (Guide C4)

NEEDS A time you adapted how you spoke to different audiences

LINE *"Switching between* **[two worlds]** *taught me that the same idea needs different words for different people, which is the heart of good selling."*

AVOID IF You used this angle for IM. Pick a different one here.

3C · Public Relations angles

1 · Who gets to tell the story

TRUTH PR shapes how organisations, people and communities are understood (Guide D1)

NEEDS A moment you saw someone (or a place, group or community) portrayed unfairly or one-dimensionally, or portrayed well

LINE *"I first noticed the power of framing when* **[moment]** *. The facts were the same, but the story told about them changed how people reacted."*

AVOID IF It turns into a political statement. Stay on communication and fairness.

2 · The reputation you carry

TRUTH Reputation is an intangible asset, slow to build and quick to lose (Guide D1)

NEEDS Being raised to remember you represent your family, school, church, team or community

LINE *"Growing up, I was always reminded that* **[the saying, e.g. 'you carry our name']** *. It's why I understand instinctively that a reputation belongs to more than one person."*

AVOID IF You can't link it to how organisations manage reputation

3 · In finance, trust is the product

TRUTH For asset managers, reputational damage becomes outflows (Woodford, Guide D6)

NEEDS Seeing how carefully your AM firm communicated

LINE *"At* **[firm]** *I saw that every market comment was checked carefully, because one careless sentence could cost clients' confidence."*

AVOID IF The answer becomes all finance. Keep it broad for consumer agencies too.

4 · The family WhatsApp problem

TRUTH Misinformation spreads in minutes, so credible communication is more valuable than ever (Guide D8)

NEEDS Seeing a false story or rumour spread among people you know, and how hard it was to correct

LINE *"I've watched a false story travel round* **[a family group chat / my school]** *faster than any correction could. It showed me how much credible, quick communication matters."*

AVOID IF You can't name a light, non-sensitive example

5 · Calm in the storm

TRUTH Crisis comms rewards calm judgement, honesty and speed (Guide D5)

NEEDS A time you were the calm one: at work, in a family moment, during an event going wrong

LINE *"When* **[situation]** *went wrong, I was the one who* **[what you did]** *. I've since realised that's what crisis communication is: deciding what people need to hear first."*

AVOID IF The example is too personal to discuss comfortably

6 · Words that changed a decision

TRUTH Key messages and framing change behaviour (Guide D3)

NEEDS A speech, message, post or conversation (yours or someone else's) that changed people's minds

LINE *"The moment I became interested in communication was when* **[who]** *changed* **[a decision]** *with* **[how few]** *well-chosen words."*

AVOID IF You can't describe what made the words work

7 · Thinking like a journalist

TRUTH The core PR skill is understanding what makes news (Guide D4)

NEEDS A news habit: what you read, a story you followed closely, writing you did

LINE *"I've always been the person who reads past the headline. Following* **[story]** *made me curious about who decides how a story is told."*

AVOID IF You don't actually follow news. They'll test it.

8 · Owning mistakes well

TRUTH Honest, human responses can rebuild trust (KFC "FCK", Guide D5)

NEEDS A value of humility or integrity, or a time you owned a mistake and it improved things

LINE *"I was raised to* **[own it when you get it wrong]** *, and the campaigns I admire most do exactly that."*

AVOID IF You can't name a real campaign or example to back it

Part 4 · Cliché detector

Recruiters read the same phrases hundreds of times. If a sentence in your draft matches the left column, replace it using the method on the right.

Cliché	Why it fails	Upgrade method
"I have always been passionate about..."	Unprovable, and everyone says it	Replace with the **moment** the interest started
"...a fast-paced, dynamic environment"	Describes every job	Name **one specific** thing about the industry's pace (e.g. a 7am results announcement)
"I want to develop my skills"	About you, not them	Say **what you'll contribute**, then what you'll learn
"I am a hard-working team player"	Adjectives without evidence	Give an **action plus a result** that shows it
"Since a young age..."	Vague and overused	Give the **actual age, place or event**
"I want to make a difference"	Means nothing on its own	Name **the problem** and **who** it affects
"I'm a people person"	Unspecific	Describe **how** you build trust with people
"Finance has always fascinated me"	Generic	Name the **mechanism** that fascinates you (compounding, fees on AUM, stewardship)
"PR appeals to my creative side"	PR is also strategy, risk and research	Pair creativity with **judgement** or **news sense**
"Sales suits my outgoing personality"	Great sales is mostly listening	Talk about **questions and listening**
"I believe I would be a great asset"	A claim, not a demonstration	Delete it. Your evidence should already show it.
Values list: "integrity, resilience, ambition"	Labels with no story	Pick **one** value, give its origin and one action

EXPERT INSIGHT

The "anyone test": read each sentence and ask, "Could any other applicant have written this?" If yes, it's either a cliché or a necessary fact. Keep necessary facts short and cut the clichés. Your aim is that at least half your sentences could *only* have been written by you.

Part 5 · Assemble: one template per industry

Each template follows the motivation chain: value → noticed → industry truth → proof → ambition. Fill each slot with your Part 1 and Part 3 material, then smooth it into prose. Aim for 230–250 words.

Slot (≈ words)	Investment Management	Sales	Public Relations
1 · Value or memory (30–40)	Your money story / a value of responsibility or patience	The first thing you sold / a value of service or persistence	The reputation you carry / a moment of framing
2 · What you noticed (20–30)	"...which taught me that..."	"...I learned that..."	"...showed me that..."
3 · Industry truth (40–50)	Fees on AUM, retention, the client-facing side, one trend	Discovery, pipeline, retention, one trend	Earned media, key messages, crisis, one trend
4 · Proof (60–80)	Your AM internship: a task and a lesson	The AM sales cycle in sales language, plus a non-finance example	AM communications, plus a writing or organising example
5 · Ambition (30–40)	What you'll contribute and want to learn	What you'll contribute and want to learn	What you'll contribute and want to learn

Worked skeleton: how the chain reads (IM, angle 1)

[1 · Value] Growing up, **[who]** taught me to **[the value, e.g. put something aside every month, however small]**. **[2 · Noticed]** But I later realised that money saved in cash was quietly losing value to inflation, and that being responsible with money is only half the job: it also has to be invested well. **[3 · Industry truth]** Investment management exists to solve exactly that problem for millions of people, through their pensions and savings. Because firms earn fees on the assets they keep, success depends on long-term trust as much as returns, which is why the client-facing side interests me most. **[4 · Proof]** At **[firm]**, I **[specific task]**, and saw how **[specific observation about clients]**. **[5 · Ambition]** I want to bring **[your strengths]** to a team that helps clients understand what they own, and to learn how portfolios are built so I can explain them with confidence.

The skeleton shows structure only. Every bracket must be replaced with something true, and the final wording should sound like you, not like this page.

Make the three answers different

	Investment Management	Sales	Public Relations
Value used			
Angle from Part 3			
Main proof story			
Trend mentioned			

If any column repeats the same value, angle or story as another, change one. Different readers may compare notes, and each answer should show a different side of you.

Part 6 · The authenticity test and interview follow-ups

Six questions to ask of every answer

1. **Is every sentence true?** No inflated roles, invented moments or borrowed stories. Interviewers probe.
2. **Could anyone else have written it?** At least half the sentences should be uniquely yours.
3. **Does the value connect to how the industry actually works?** Not just "I like it", but a mechanism (AUM fees, discovery, earned media).
4. **Is the value shown, not labelled?** An origin and an action, not a list of adjectives.
5. **Would I happily talk about this for two minutes?** If not, swap it for a story you're comfortable expanding on.
6. **Does it end looking forward?** What you'll contribute and learn, not a summary of the past.

Prepare for "tell me more"

Whatever you write becomes interview material. For each answer, prepare a 60–90 second spoken version of the story, and answers to these likely follow-ups:

If you wrote about...	Expect to be asked...
A family value or money memory	"How has that shaped decisions you've made?" "How would you explain investing to that person today?"
Your AM internship	"What did the firm do well or badly?" "What would you change about how they served clients?"
An industry trend	"What's your view on it?" "How should a firm like ours respond?"
Selling or persuading	"Sell me something." "Tell me about a time you failed to persuade someone."
Reputation or communication	"What's a recent PR campaign or crisis you found interesting, and why?"

Next step

Do Part 1 today. Then send me your rough answers: even messy bullet points about your money story, top 5 values, the moments in 1C and your AM observations in 1D. I'll pick the strongest angle for each industry and draft all three 250-word answers in your voice, using only what's true.

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